Phase 8: Twelve Mighty Messengers

The 12 Minor Prophets, Hosea through Malachi: short books with BIG messages, finishing the Old Testament. Plus the "400 Silent Years" bridge that leads us to Jesus.

At a Glance

Month	Month 8
Books covered	Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi (**12 books**)
Bible section(s)	Minor Prophets (Old Testament), which **completes the Old Testament (39 books)**, plus the bridge between the Testaments
Big Idea	God's twelve "short-book" messengers said: God loves you, God is fair, turn back to Him, and the King and His messenger are coming!
Memory Verse (all ages)	"He has shown you, O mortal, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"Walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8)
Theme color	Ocean Blue (for Jonah's sea and the "bridge" waters we cross to the New Testament)
Phase symbol / badge	🐋 The Big Fish + 🌉 the Bridge, "Mighty Twelve" badge
Running total of books learned	**39 of 66: the WHOLE Old Testament!** (Law 5 + History 12 + Poetry/Wisdom 5 + Major Prophets 5 + Minor Prophets 12)

> Cross-links: Program Overview · Teacher Training Guide · Books of the Bible Memory System · Game Library · YouTube Video Guide · Phase 8 Printables

The Big Idea (in kid words)

The Minor Prophets are **twelve** messengers with **short** books. "Minor" means *small book*, not *small message*! Some of them warned, "Turn back to God!" Some said, "God loves you even when you run away," just like Jonah found out inside a big fish. Then, after Malachi, God was quiet for about **400 years**. But God wasn't gone. He was getting the world ready for **Jesus**!

How this points to Jesus: These little books are packed with big clues about Jesus. **Micah** said the King would be born in **Bethlehem**. **Zechariah** said the King would ride into Jerusalem on a **donkey**. **Jonah** spent three days in the fish, and Jesus said that was a picture of His three days in the tomb. **Malachi**, the very last book of the Old Testament, said, "I will send my messenger, who will prepare the way." That messenger was John the Baptist, who got people ready for Jesus. The Old Testament ends by pointing straight ahead to Jesus!

The Books in Easy Words

> **Teacher tip:** In the Hebrew Bible, these twelve were copied together on **one scroll** called "The Book of the Twelve." A good way to remember them is in **three groups of four**:
>
> - **Group 1:** Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah ("**H-J-A-O**": "**H**appy **J**ellyfish **A**te **O**ranges")
> - **Group 2:** Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk ("**J-M-N-H**": "**J**onah **M**et **N**ine **H**ungry fish")
> - **Group 3:** Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi ("**Z-H-Z-M**": "**Z**ebras **H**op, **Z**ebras **M**arch")

1. Hosea ❤️

How to say it	ho-ZAY-uh
How to spell it	Ho-se-a — **H-O-S-E-A**
Section	Minor Prophets (1 of 12)
Traditional author	Hosea son of Beeri, prophet to the northern kingdom (Israel), about 755–715 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	God told Hosea to keep loving his wife even when she ran away, to show how God keeps loving His people even when they run from Him.
In one word	**Faithful love**
Key people	Hosea, his wife Gomer, their children Jezreel, Lo-Ruhamah ("not loved") and Lo-Ammi ("not my people"), whose names God later turns around: "loved" and "my people" (2:23)
Key stories	Hosea marries Gomer (ch. 1); God's promise to win back His people (ch. 2); Hosea buys Gomer back (ch. 3); "I desire mercy, not sacrifice" (6:6); "out of Egypt I called my son" (11:1); "Return, Israel, to the LORD your God" (ch. 14)
Where Jesus shows up	Matthew 2:15 says Jesus coming back from Egypt fulfilled Hosea 11:1. Jesus quoted Hosea 6:6 twice (Matthew 9:13; 12:7). Like Hosea paying to buy back Gomer, Jesus paid to buy us back (redeem us).
Hand motion / symbol	❤️ **"Come home!"**: stretch both arms out wide, then pull them back in to your chest like you're bringing someone home: "God's love won't quit!"

2. Joel 🦗

How to say it	JOE-ul
How to spell it	Jo-el — **J-O-E-L**
Section	Minor Prophets (2 of 12)
Traditional author	Joel son of Pethuel (Joel 1:1); his date is uncertain (suggestions range from the 800s to the 400s B.C.).
One-sentence kid summary	After a giant swarm of locusts ate up all the crops, Joel told the people to turn back to God and promised that one day God would pour out His Spirit on everyone.

In one word	**Spirit**
Key people	Joel, the people of Judah, the priests
Key stories	A huge locust plague (ch. 1); the "Day of the LORD" (ch. 2); "Rend your heart and not your garments" (2:13); "I will repay you for the years the locusts have eaten" (2:25); "I will pour out my Spirit on all people" (2:28–32)
Where Jesus shows up	On the day of Pentecost, after Jesus went back to heaven, Peter stood up and said, "This is what was spoken by the prophet Joel" (Acts 2:16–21) as the Holy Spirit came. Joel 2:32, "Everyone who calls on the name of the LORD will be saved," is quoted in Romans 10:13 about Jesus.
Hand motion / symbol	🦗 **Locust swarm**: wiggle all ten fingers in the air and buzz!

3. Amos 📏

How to say it	AY-mus
How to spell it	A-mos — **A-M-O-S**
Section	Minor Prophets (3 of 12)
Traditional author	Amos, a shepherd and fig-tree farmer from Tekoa in Judah (Amos 1:1; 7:14), who preached to the northern kingdom about 760–750 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	God sent a shepherd named Amos to tell rich people to stop being unfair to the poor, because God wants justice to flow like a river.
In one word	**Justice** (fairness)
Key people	Amos, King Jeroboam II, Amaziah the priest of Bethel
Key stories	God's roar against the nations, then Israel (ch. 1–2); the "cows of Bashan" (rich, greedy women, 4:1); "Let justice roll on like a river" (5:24); the plumb line vision (7:7–8); Amaziah tells Amos to go home (7:10–17); the basket of ripe fruit (ch. 8); God will rebuild David's fallen shelter (9:11)
Where Jesus shows up	James quoted Amos 9:11–12 in Acts 15:16–17 to show that Jesus' kingdom welcomes all nations. Jesus is the King from David's family who rebuilds the "fallen tent." Jesus also cared deeply for the poor (Luke 4:18).
Hand motion / symbol	📏 **Plumb line**: hold one fist up high and let a pretend string drop straight down: "Is it straight?"

4. Obadiah ☝️

How to say it	oh-buh-DIE-uh
How to spell it	O-ba-di-ah — **O-B-A-D-I-A-H**
Section	Minor Prophets (4 of 12)
Traditional author	Obadiah (his name means "servant of the LORD"), probably soon after Jerusalem fell in 586 B.C.

One-sentence kid summary	Obadiah, the shortest book in the Old Testament (just 21 verses), warned the nation of Edom that it would be punished for cheering when Jerusalem was hurt.
In one word	**Pride**
Key people	Obadiah, the nation of Edom (descendants of Esau, Jacob's twin brother)
Key stories	Proud Edom lives high in the rocky cliffs (v. 3–4); Edom stood by and gloated when Jerusalem fell (v. 10–14); "As you have done, it will be done to you" (v. 15); "the kingdom will be the LORD's" (v. 21)
Where Jesus shows up	Obadiah ends with "the kingdom will be the LORD's" (v. 21). Jesus came preaching "the kingdom of God has come near" (Mark 1:15). Jesus teaches us to love even our enemies instead of cheering when they fall.
Hand motion / symbol	☝️ **One finger**: hold up one finger: "Obadiah: one chapter!"

5. Jonah 🐋

How to say it	JOE-nuh
How to spell it	Jo-nah — **J-O-N-A-H**
Section	Minor Prophets (5 of 12)
Traditional author	About Jonah son of Amittai, a prophet in the days of King Jeroboam II (2 Kings 14:25), around 780–750 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	Jonah ran away from God, got swallowed by a big fish, and finally preached to Nineveh, where everyone said sorry to God, showing that God loves even enemies.
In one word	**Second chance**
Key people	Jonah, the sailors, the king and people of Nineveh (capital of Assyria)
Key stories	Jonah runs the opposite way on a ship to Tarshish (ch. 1); the storm; thrown overboard; swallowed by a great fish for three days and three nights (1:17); Jonah prays inside the fish: "Salvation comes from the LORD" (ch. 2); Nineveh repents (ch. 3); Jonah pouts under a plant, and God teaches him about mercy (ch. 4)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus said, "For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of a huge fish, so the Son of Man will be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth" (Matthew 12:40), a picture of His death and resurrection. Jesus is "greater than Jonah" (Matthew 12:41).
Hand motion / symbol	🐋 **Fish gulp**: put your hands together like a fish's mouth, open wide and "GULP!"

6. Micah 🏘️

How to say it	MY-kuh
How to spell it	Mi-cah — **M-I-C-A-H**
Section	Minor Prophets (6 of 12)

Traditional author	Micah of Moresheth, a small-town prophet in Judah, about 735–700 B.C., at the same time as Isaiah
One-sentence kid summary	Micah told God's people to be fair, kind and humble, and he said the great King would be born in little Bethlehem.
In one word	**Bethlehem**
Key people	Micah, Kings Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah (1:1)
Key stories	Swords will be turned into plowshares (4:3); "But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah… out of you will come for me one who will be ruler over Israel" (5:2); "act justly… love mercy… walk humbly" (6:8); God hurls our sins into the depths of the sea (7:19)
Where Jesus shows up	When the wise men asked where the King would be born, the chief priests quoted Micah 5:2: Bethlehem! (Matthew 2:1–6). Micah also said this Ruler's "origins are from of old, from ancient times." Jesus existed before He was born.
Hand motion / symbol	🏘️ **Little town**: make a tiny roof with your fingertips: "Little Bethlehem!"

7. Nahum 🏰

How to say it	NAY-hum
How to spell it	Na-hum — **N-A-H-U-M**
Section	Minor Prophets (7 of 12)
Traditional author	Nahum the Elkoshite (1:1), between 663 and 612 B.C. (his name means "comfort")
One-sentence kid summary	About 100+ years after Jonah, Nineveh went back to being cruel, so Nahum announced that God would stop Nineveh, which was comforting news for everyone they had hurt.
In one word	**Comfort** (God stops bullies)
Key people	Nahum, the city of Nineveh (Assyria)
Key stories	"The LORD is slow to anger but great in power" (1:3); "The LORD is good, a refuge in times of trouble" (1:7); "Look, there on the mountains, the feet of one who brings good news" (1:15); the fall of Nineveh (ch. 2–3), which happened in 612 B.C.
Where Jesus shows up	"The feet of one who brings good news, who proclaims peace!" (1:15; see Isaiah 52:7 and Romans 10:15). Jesus brings the best good news. Jesus will one day end all evil and cruelty forever.
Hand motion / symbol	🏰 **Tower tumbles**: stack fists on top of each other high, then let them crumble down.

8. Habakkuk ❓

How to say it	huh-BAK-uk
How to spell it	Ha-bak-kuk — **H-A-B-A-K-K-U-K** (tip: double K in the middle! "Ha-BAK-KUK," like a chicken: "bak-kuk!")

Section	Minor Prophets (8 of 12)
Traditional author	Habakkuk, in Judah about 610–600 B.C., just before Babylon invaded
One-sentence kid summary	Habakkuk asked God hard "Why?" questions, waited for God's answer, and decided to trust and rejoice in God even when everything went wrong.
In one word	**Trust**
Key people	Habakkuk, the Babylonians
Key stories	"How long, LORD, must I call for help?" (1:2); God's surprising answer: He will use Babylon (1:5–11); Habakkuk climbs his watchtower to wait (2:1); "The righteous person will live by his faithfulness" (2:4); "The earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD as the waters cover the sea" (2:14); "Though the fig tree does not bud… yet I will rejoice in the LORD" (3:17–18)
Where Jesus shows up	Habakkuk 2:4 is quoted three times in the New Testament (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:38) to explain that we are made right with God by faith in Jesus.
Hand motion / symbol	👀 **Watchtower**: hand over your eyes like you're looking far away: "Watch and wait!"

9. Zephaniah 🎶

How to say it	zef-uh-NIE-uh
How to spell it	Zeph-a-ni-ah — **Z-E-P-H-A-N-I-A-H** (tip: "PH" makes the "F" sound.)
Section	Minor Prophets (9 of 12)
Traditional author	Zephaniah, a great-great-grandson of King Hezekiah (1:1), in the days of King Josiah (about 640–609 B.C.)
One-sentence kid summary	Zephaniah warned about the "Day of the LORD," but ended with a happy promise that God will rejoice over His people with singing.
In one word	**Singing**
Key people	Zephaniah, King Josiah
Key stories	The Day of the LORD is near (ch. 1); "Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land" (2:3); judgment on the nations (ch. 2); "The LORD your God is with you, the Mighty Warrior who saves. He will take great delight in you… but will rejoice over you with singing" (3:17)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is the "Mighty Warrior who saves" who is "with you" (Immanuel). Jesus said heaven throws a party when one sinner repents (Luke 15:7, 10).
Hand motion / symbol	🎶 **Song from the heart**: hands start at your heart and float outward like music notes.

10. Haggai 🔨

How to say it	HAG-eye
How to spell it	Hag-gai — **H-A-G-G-A-I** (tip: double G! "HAG-GAI," and it ends in "A-I.")

Section	Minor Prophets (10 of 12)
Traditional author	Haggai, after the people came home from Babylon; all four of his messages are dated to 520 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	Haggai told the people who had come home from exile to stop working only on their own houses and finish building God's temple.
In one word	**Build**
Key people	Haggai, Zerubbabel the governor, Joshua the high priest (see Ezra 5:1)
Key stories	"Is it a time for you yourselves to be living in your paneled houses, while this house remains a ruin?" (1:4); "Give careful thought to your ways" (1:5, 7); the people obey and start building (1:12–15); "The glory of this present house will be greater than the glory of the former house" (2:9); Zerubbabel like a signet ring (2:23)
Where Jesus shows up	Zerubbabel is in Jesus' family line (Matthew 1:12). Jesus Himself came to the rebuilt temple, which made its glory "greater." Jesus called His body the true temple (John 2:19–21).
Hand motion / symbol	🔨 **Hammer + roof**: pound one fist on the other palm twice, then make a roof over your head with both hands: "Build God's house!"

11. Zechariah 🫏

How to say it	zek-uh-RYE-uh
How to spell it	Zech-a-ri-ah — **Z-E-C-H-A-R-I-A-H** (tip: "CH" sounds like "K" here.)
Section	Minor Prophets (11 of 12)
Traditional author	Zechariah son of Berekiah, son of Iddo (1:1), a priest-prophet who started in 520 B.C., at the same time as Haggai
One-sentence kid summary	Zechariah encouraged the people with eight night visions and many promises about the coming King, including that He would ride into Jerusalem on a donkey.
In one word	**King** (on a donkey)
Key people	Zechariah, Zerubbabel, Joshua the high priest, angels
Key stories	Eight night visions (ch. 1–6), including horses, a measuring line, Joshua the high priest getting clean clothes, and a golden lampstand: "'Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit,' says the LORD Almighty" (4:6); the King on a donkey (9:9); thirty pieces of silver (11:12–13); "They will look on me, the one they have pierced" (12:10); "Strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered" (13:7); the LORD stands on the Mount of Olives (14:4)
Where Jesus shows up	Everywhere! Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey on Palm Sunday (Matthew 21:4–5; John 12:14–15). Judas was paid thirty pieces of silver (Matthew 26:15; 27:9–10). Jesus quoted "strike the shepherd" (Matthew 26:31). John 19:37 says Jesus' pierced side fulfilled 12:10.
Hand motion / symbol	🫏 **Donkey ride**: hold pretend reins and bounce gently: "Here comes the King!"

12. Malachi 📣

How to say it	MAL-uh-kie
How to spell it	Mal-a-chi — **M-A-L-A-C-H-I** (tip: ends in "CHI," which sounds like "KYE.")
Section	Minor Prophets (12 of 12), the **last book of the Old Testament**
Traditional author	Malachi (the name means "my messenger"), about 450–430 B.C., around the time of Nehemiah
One-sentence kid summary	Malachi told the people to stop giving God their leftovers and promised that God would send a messenger to get everyone ready for the Lord.
In one word	**Messenger**
Key people	Malachi, the priests, the people of Judah; "Elijah" (the coming messenger)
Key stories	"I have loved you," says the LORD (1:2); priests offering blind, lame and sick animals (1:6–14); "Will a mere mortal rob God?" Bring the whole tithe (3:8–10); "I the LORD do not change" (3:6); "I will send my messenger, who will prepare the way before me" (3:1); "the sun of righteousness will rise with healing in its rays" (4:2); "I will send the prophet Elijah to you before that great and dreadful day of the LORD comes" (4:5–6)
Where Jesus shows up	The messenger "preparing the way" is John the Baptist (Mark 1:2; Matthew 11:10). Jesus said John was the "Elijah who was to come" (Matthew 11:14; see Luke 1:17). Then the Lord Himself, Jesus, came to His temple!
Hand motion / symbol	📣 **Point ahead**: cup one hand by your mouth and point far forward with the other: "He's coming!"

Section summary: The Minor Prophets (12)

#	Book	One word	Motion
1	Hosea	Faithful love	Arms out, pull back in ("Come home!")
2	Joel	Spirit	Locust fingers
3	Amos	Justice	Plumb line
4	Obadiah	Pride	One finger
5	Jonah	Second chance	Fish gulp
6	Micah	Bethlehem	Tiny roof
7	Nahum	Comfort	Tower tumbles
8	Habakkuk	Trust	Watchtower
9	Zephaniah	Singing	Song from the heart
10	Haggai	Build	Hammer, then roof over head
11	Zechariah	King on a donkey	Donkey ride
12	Malachi	Messenger	Point ahead

🌉 Bonus: The Bridge, "The 400 Silent Years"

What it is	Not a book! It's the time *between* Malachi (the last Old Testament book, about 430 B.C.) and the first events in the New Testament (about 6–5 B.C.).
How to say it	"The Four Hundred Silent Years" (also called the "intertestamental period," IN-ter-tes-ta-MEN-tal, meaning "between the Testaments")
One-sentence kid summary	For about 400 years God didn't send any new prophets or Bible books, but He was busy getting the whole world ready for Jesus.
In one word	**Waiting** (and **Getting Ready**)
Key people & empires	The Persians; Alexander the Great (Greece); Judas Maccabeus ("the Hammer"); the Romans; Herod the Great
Key events	Greek becomes the common language; the Old Testament is translated into Greek (the Septuagint); a wicked king (Antiochus IV) messes up the temple; the Maccabees take it back and rededicate it (that's where Hanukkah comes from, see John 10:22); Rome takes over; roads are built; people long for the Messiah
Where Jesus shows up	"But when the set time had fully come, God sent his Son" (Galatians 4:4). The silence is broken when the angel Gabriel (the same angel from Daniel!) visits a priest named Zechariah in the temple to announce John the Baptist (Luke 1).
Hand motion / symbol	🌉 **Bridge**: make an arch with one arm from left to right while you whisper "shhh" (silent), then shout "JESUS!" at the end

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

Why "Minor"? "Minor" means *shorter*, not *less important*. Their combined length is about the size of Isaiah. In the Hebrew Bible they were copied onto a single scroll called "The Twelve."

Order isn't strictly chronological. The twelve are arranged roughly by time, with the earlier (Assyrian-era) prophets first and the post-exile prophets last, but not perfectly. Here's a simple timeline to keep in your head:

Era	Approx. date (B.C.)	Prophets	Main audience
Assyrian era (before the North fell in 722)	780–700	Jonah, Amos, Hosea, Micah (Joel's date uncertain)	Jonah → Nineveh; Amos & Hosea → Israel (North); Micah → Judah (South)
Before Babylon (Judah alone)	663–600	Nahum, Zephaniah, Habakkuk	Nahum → Nineveh's fall; Zephaniah & Habakkuk → Judah
After Jerusalem falls	after 586	Obadiah	Edom
After the return home	520–430	Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi	The returned exiles in Jerusalem

Connections to earlier phases:

- Jonah and Amos ministered under **Jeroboam II** (2 Kings 14:23–25), from Phase 4.
- Micah ministered under **Hezekiah**, alongside **Isaiah** (Phase 7). Jeremiah 26:18 quotes Micah!
- Zephaniah ministered under **Josiah**, the boy king who found the Book of the Law (Phase 4).
- Haggai and Zechariah are named in **Ezra 5:1 and 6:14** (Phase 5); they encouraged the rebuilding of the temple, finished in 516 B.C.
- Malachi likely ministered around the time of **Nehemiah** (Phase 5); both deal with careless worship, tithing and marriage problems.

Recurring themes in the Twelve:

1. **The Day of the LORD:** a coming day when God sets everything right, bad news for the proud and wicked, good news for the humble (Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Zephaniah, Malachi).
2. **God's covenant love (hesed):** God's loyal, never-quitting love (Hosea, Micah 7:18–20, Jonah 4:2).
3. **Justice for the poor:** God hates religious show without kindness and fairness (Amos, Micah).
4. **God over all nations:** God cares about Nineveh, judges Edom and Assyria, and plans to bless all nations (Jonah, Nahum, Obadiah, Zechariah 8:20–23).
5. **The coming King and His messenger** (Micah 5, Zechariah 9–14, Malachi 3–4).

🌉 Bridge background: the 400 "Silent" Years (teacher notes)

"Silent" means **no new inspired prophet or Scripture** between Malachi and John the Baptist. It does **not** mean God was absent. Daniel had already predicted some of these empires (Daniel 2, 7, 8, 11). Here is a simple timeline:

Approx. date	What happened	Why it matters for the Gospels
~430 B.C.	Malachi's ministry; Nehemiah's governorship; Persia rules	The Old Testament closes.
333–332 B.C.	**Alexander the Great** (Greece) conquers the Persian Empire, including Judea	**Greek** becomes the common language of the Mediterranean world; the New Testament will be written in everyday (Koine) Greek.
323 B.C.	Alexander dies; his generals split his empire. The **Ptolemies** (Egypt) control Judea for about a century.	
~250 B.C. (3rd century)	Jewish scholars in Alexandria, Egypt, begin translating the Hebrew Scriptures into Greek: the **Septuagint** (often abbreviated LXX).	Non-Jews could now read God's Word; the apostles often quoted it.
198 B.C.	The **Seleucids** (Syria) take control of Judea.	
167 B.C.	Seleucid king **Antiochus IV Epiphanes** outlaws Jewish worship and defiles the temple with a pagan altar and sacrifice.	Compare Daniel 11:31.

Approx. date	What happened	Why it matters for the Gospels
167–164 B.C.	The **Maccabean revolt**: a priest named Mattathias and his sons, led by **Judas Maccabeus** ("the Hammer"), fight back. In 164 B.C. they cleanse and rededicate the temple.	This is the origin of **Hanukkah**, the "Festival of Dedication," which Jesus attended (John 10:22–23).
164–63 B.C.	Jewish self-rule under the Hasmonean family. Groups like the **Pharisees** and **Sadducees** form; **synagogues** spread.	These groups and synagogues appear all through the Gospels.
63 B.C.	Roman general **Pompey** captures Jerusalem; **Rome** takes over.	Roman roads, Roman peace (Pax Romana), Roman soldiers, taxes and crosses appear in the Gospels.
37 B.C.	**Herod the Great**, appointed by Rome, becomes king of Judea (ruling until 4 B.C.); about 20/19 B.C. he begins a massive rebuilding of the temple.	The Herod of Matthew 2; the temple of the Gospels (John 2:20, "forty-six years to build").
27 B.C.	**Caesar Augustus** becomes the first Roman emperor.	His census brings Mary and Joseph to Bethlehem (Luke 2:1).
~6–5 B.C.	Gabriel appears to **Zechariah the priest** in the temple (Luke 1).	**The silence is broken!**
~6–4 B.C.	**Jesus is born** in Bethlehem (Herod died in 4 B.C., so Jesus was born a little before that).	"When the set time had fully come, God sent his Son" (Galatians 4:4).

Three ways God "prepared the stage": (1) **One language** (Greek) for spreading the gospel; (2) **Roads and peace** (Rome) for travel; (3) **A hungry heart**: synagogues full of Scripture and people longing for the Messiah (Luke 2:25, 38).

A note on the Apocrypha. Catholic and Orthodox Bibles include some books written during this period (such as 1 and 2 Maccabees), called the Apocrypha or Deuterocanonical books. Protestant Christians value some of them as helpful history (1 Maccabees is a key source for the Hanukkah story), but don't count them as Scripture, in line with the Hebrew Bible Jesus used. If a kid asks, keep it simple and respectful: "Some Bibles include extra history books from this time. In our church we read them as history, not as God's Word."

Key truths to emphasize

- **God's love doesn't quit** (Hosea, Jonah).
- **God cares how we treat others**: fairness, kindness, humility (Amos, Micah 6:8).
- **We can bring God our hard questions** and still trust Him (Habakkuk).
- **God gives second chances**, to Jonah and to Nineveh.
- **Put God first** (Haggai, Malachi).
- **God keeps His promises on His schedule**: 400 years of waiting ended with Jesus right on time.

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Hosea's unfaithful wife (Gomer)	"Hosea's wife ran away and stopped loving him back, but Hosea kept loving her and brought her home."	Same; "She loved other things more than her husband."	"She was unfaithful to her marriage." Explain that it pictures Israel worshiping idols.	Discuss the marriage metaphor for covenant and idolatry plainly but modestly. Skip the explicit language in ch. 2.
Nineveh's cruelty / Nahum's destruction	"Nineveh was a mean city that hurt people."	Assyria was cruel to many nations; God stopped them.	Discuss God's patience (Jonah, ~150 years earlier) and justice (Nahum).	Discuss justice, wrath and mercy; why God's judgment is good news for victims.
Jonah thrown overboard	Focus on the fish as God's rescue.	Tell the full story.	Discuss Jonah's choice and the sailors' fear of God.	Discuss Jonah's racism/nationalism; he wanted his enemies destroyed.
Day of the LORD / judgment language	"One day God will make everything right."	God will judge evil; people who trust Him have nothing to fear.	Explore both sides: dark for the proud, bright for the humble (Malachi 4:1–2).	Connect to the second coming and final judgment.
Antiochus defiling the temple	Skip details: "A bad king messed up God's temple."	Same, plus the Maccabees cleaning it.	Mention the pagan altar and sacrifice.	Discuss persecution and faithfulness, and Daniel 11 connections.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

1. **"Could a person really live inside a fish?"** God made the fish and sent it to save Jonah (Jonah 1:17). It was a miracle. Jesus talked about Jonah as a real event (Matthew 12:40–41), so we believe it too. The Bible says "a huge fish," not specifically a whale.
2. **"Why did Jonah run away?"** Nineveh was the capital of Assyria, an enemy nation that was very cruel. Jonah didn't want God to forgive them (Jonah 4:2). God wanted to show that His love is for everyone.
3. **"What does 'walk humbly' mean?"** It means living close to God, knowing He is the boss, and not acting like we're better than other people.
4. **"Why was God quiet for 400 years?"** God was waiting for exactly the right time (Galatians 4:4). He had already said everything the people needed until the Messiah came. He was quietly getting the world ready.
5. **"Is God quiet now?"** No! God has spoken to us through His Son, Jesus (Hebrews 1:1–2), and through the Bible, and the Holy Spirit lives in everyone who trusts Jesus.
6. **"What's a tithe?"** A tithe means "a tenth." God's people gave a tenth of their crops and animals to God. Malachi said bringing it showed they trusted God to provide.

7. **"Who is the Elijah Malachi talks about?"** Jesus said it was John the Baptist, who came "in the spirit and power of Elijah" (Luke 1:17; Matthew 11:14). He wasn't Elijah come back to life, but a prophet like him.
8. **"Why do Zechariah and Malachi seem confusing?"** They have visions and symbols, kind of like a picture puzzle. We focus on the clear parts, especially the promises about Jesus.

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Hosea 3:1–5; 11:1–4; Joel 2:12–13, 28; Amos 5:24; 7:7–8; Obadiah 15	"Love That Won't Quit" (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah)	God loves us faithfully and wants us to be fair and humble.	BibleProject "Overview: Hosea," "Joel," "Amos," "Obadiah"; Sharefaith Kids "Hosea"; Bible Journey "Amos"	Minor Prophet Line-Up Race	Heart Chain / Plumb Line Craft
2	Jonah 1–4; Micah 5:2; 6:8; Nahum 1:7	"Jonah Runs, God Rescues" (Jonah, Micah, Nahum)	God gives second chances and loves everyone, even enemies.	BibleProject "Overview: Jonah," "Micah," "Nahum"; Sharefaith Kids "Jonah"; Bible Journey "Jonah"	Jonah Overboard!	Paper-Bag Big Fish
3	Habakkuk 1:2; 2:1–4; 3:17–19; Zephaniah 3:17; Haggai 1:2–8, 12–14; Zechariah 4:6; 9:9	"Watch, Build & Trust" (Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah)	Trust God when life is hard, put Him first, and look for the King.	BibleProject "Overview: Habakkuk," "Zephaniah," "Haggai," "Zechariah"; Sharefaith Kids "Haggai Rebuild"; Bible Journey "Zechariah"	Temple Builders Relay	Palm-Branch Donkey Parade
4	Malachi 3:1, 6; 4:2, 5–6; Galatians 4:4; Luke 1:5–17	"The Messenger Is Coming" (Malachi + 🕍 the 400 Silent Years)	God was quiet but not gone; He got the world ready for Jesus right on time.	BibleProject "Overview: Malachi" & theme video "Messiah"; Sharefaith Kids "Zechariah and Elizabeth"; Bible Journey "Between the Testaments" / "Malachi"	Cross the Silent Bridge	Bridge Timeline Walk

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
5 *(optional)*	Review: all 39 OT books	"Old Testament Graduation Sunday"	We know the whole Old Testament, and it all points to Jesus!	Favorite clips + BibleProject "The Covenants"	Old Testament Library Sort	Passport Stamp, Badge & OT Graduation

📅 2nd & 4th Sunday Plan

Our class meets on the **2nd and 4th Sundays** of each month, so the four lessons below are taught **two at a time**. Each Sunday is still 75 minutes, with two shorter stories. Use the full lesson write-ups in **Weekly Lessons** for scripts, questions and supplies.

Sunday	2027 date*	Teach	Big takeaway
2nd Sunday	Aug 8	**Lesson 1: "Love That Won't Quit" (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah)"** (Hosea 3:1–5; 11:1–4; Joel 2:12–13, 28; Amos 5:24; 7:7–8; Obadiah 15) + **Lesson 2: "Jonah Runs, God Rescues" (Jonah, Micah, Nahum)"** (Jonah 1–4; Micah 5:2; 6:8; Nahum 1:7)	God loves us faithfully and wants us to be fair and humble. God gives second chances and loves everyone, even enemies.
4th Sunday	Aug 22	**Lesson 3: "Watch, Build & Trust" (Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah)"** (Habakkuk 1:2; 2:1–4; 3:17–19; Zephaniah 3:17; Haggai 1:2–8, 12–14; Zechariah 4:6; 9:9) + **Lesson 4: "The Messenger Is Coming" (Malachi + 🕍 the 400 Silent Years)"** (Malachi 3:1, 6; 4:2, 5–6; Galatians 4:4; Luke 1:5–17) + **End-of-Phase Review**	Trust God when life is hard, put Him first, and look for the King. God was quiet but not gone; He got the world ready for Jesus right on time.

**Dates assume a January 2027 start. See the Program Overview for the full calendar.*

2nd Sunday: "Love That Won't Quit" (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah)" + "Jonah Runs, God Rescues" (Jonah, Micah, Nahum)"

Time	Segment	What to do
0:00–0:08	🎵 Welcome & Book Chant	Attendance, then sing this phase's book song with motions.
0:08–0:20	📖 Story 1	**Love That Won't Quit" (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah)** (Hosea 3:1–5; 11:1–4; Joel 2:12–13, 28; Amos 5:24; 7:7–8; Obadiah 15). Use the Lesson 1 hook and story script. Key point: *God loves us faithfully and wants us to be fair and humble.*
0:20–0:28	📺 Video	Show **one** video (Little Lambs & Explorers: Sharefaith Kids; Trailblazers & Ambassadors: BibleProject). Options: BibleProject "Overview: Hosea," "Joel," "Amos," "Obadiah"; Sharefaith Kids "Hosea"; Bible Journey "Amos". Send the others home on the family page.

Time	Segment	What to do
0:28–0:40	📖 Story 2	**Jonah Runs, God Rescues" (Jonah, Micah, Nahum)** (Jonah 1–4; Micah 5:2; 6:8; Nahum 1:7). Use the Lesson 2 script. Key point: *God gives second chances and loves everyone, even enemies.*
0:40–0:48	💬 Small Groups	Ask 1 question from Lesson 1 and 1 from Lesson 2 for your age group, then: "Where did we see Jesus today?"
0:48–0:58	🎮 Game	**Minor Prophet Line-Up Race** (Lesson 1). Backup: Jonah Overboard!.
0:58–1:10	🖍️ Activity	**Paper-Bag Big Fish** (Lesson 2). Early finishers: this phase's coloring page or word search.
1:10–1:15	✅ Memory, Spelling & Prayer	Say the memory verse, spell 1–2 new books together, give stars, and pray. Send home the Take-Home Family Page.

4th Sunday: "Watch, Build & Trust" (Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah)" + "The Messenger Is Coming" (Malachi + 🌉 the 400 Silent Years)"

Time	Segment	What to do
0:00–0:08	🎵 Welcome & Book Chant	Attendance, then sing this phase's book song with motions. Then a 2-minute recap: "What do you remember from last time?"
0:08–0:20	📖 Story 1	**Watch, Build & Trust" (Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah)** (Habakkuk 1:2; 2:1–4; 3:17–19; Zephaniah 3:17; Haggai 1:2–8, 12–14; Zechariah 4:6; 9:9). Use the Lesson 3 hook and story script. Key point: *Trust God when life is hard, put Him first, and look for the King.*
0:20–0:28	📺 Video	Show **one** video (Little Lambs & Explorers: Sharefaith Kids; Trailblazers & Ambassadors: BibleProject). Options: BibleProject "Overview: Habakkuk," "Zephaniah," "Haggai," "Zechariah"; Sharefaith Kids "Haggai Rebuild"; Bible Journey "Zechariah". Send the others home on the family page.
0:28–0:40	📖 Story 2	**The Messenger Is Coming" (Malachi + 🌉 the 400 Silent Years)** (Malachi 3:1, 6; 4:2, 5–6; Galatians 4:4; Luke 1:5–17). Use the Lesson 4 script. Key point: *God was quiet but not gone; He got the world ready for Jesus right on time.*
0:40–0:48	💬 Small Groups	Ask 1 question from Lesson 3 and 1 from Lesson 4 for your age group, then: "Where did we see Jesus today?"
0:48–0:56	🎮 Game	**Temple Builders Relay** (Lesson 3). Backup: Cross the Silent Bridge.
0:56–1:04	🖍️ Activity	**Bridge Timeline Walk** (Lesson 4). Early finishers: this phase's coloring page or word search.
1:04–1:15	✅ Review, Passport & Prayer	Run the **End-of-Phase** oral check-offs by age group, stamp Bible Passports, hand out the phase badge, and pray. Anyone not finished can check off on the next 2nd Sunday.

🏠 Between Sundays (the 1st and 3rd weeks)

Kids go two weeks between classes, so the home weeks keep the memory work going. Put these on the family page or text them to parents:

- **After the 2nd Sunday:** Sing the book song once a day, practice this phase's spelling words (5 minutes), read or listen to Hosea 3:1–5; 11:1–4; Joel 2:12–13, 28; Amos 5:24; 7:7–8; Obadiah 15 and Jonah 1–4; Micah 5:2; 6:8; Nahum 1:7 with a picture Bible, and watch the video the class didn't see.
- **After the 4th Sunday:** Read Malachi 3:1, 6; 4:2, 5–6; Galatians 4:4; Luke 1:5–17 together, talk through the 3 dinner-table questions, and keep singing the whole song so far. The next phase starts on the 2nd Sunday!
- **Teachers:** A quick text or photo to parents mid-week ("This week, practice spelling ___!") makes a big difference.

✂️ What to Trim When Time Is Short

Two lessons in one Sunday means you **won't use everything** in the Weekly Lessons. Keep these, in this order: (1) both story scripts, (2) the memory verse and book song, (3) one game, (4) one activity. Extra games, crafts, trivia and puzzles become take-home pages, early-finisher options or fun for a 5th-Sunday or special event.

> 💡 **Optional bonus:** "Old Testament Graduation Sunday" (the old Week 5 review) can be used for a special event, a 5th Sunday if your church holds class, or folded into the 4th Sunday's review time.

Weekly Lessons

> 📅 **Twice a month:** The four lessons below are taught in pairs: **Lessons 1 & 2 on the 2nd Sunday**, **Lessons 3 & 4 on the 4th Sunday**. See the 2nd & 4th Sunday Plan above for the 75-minute run sheets. "Week 1–4" below means Lesson 1–4.

Week 1: "Love That Won't Quit" (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah)

Scripture: Hosea 3:1–5; 11:1–4; Joel 2:12–13, 28; Amos 5:24; 7:7–8; Obadiah 15

Lesson goal: Kids will learn the first four Minor Prophets, that God's love for His people never quits (Hosea), that God wants our hearts to turn back to Him (Joel), and that God cares about fairness (Amos) and humility (Obadiah).

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Rubber Band Love"

- *Supplies:* A sturdy rubber band, a toy heart or red paper heart, a string with a weight tied on (a washer or key) to be a "plumb line," a ruler.

- *Do:* Stretch the rubber band far: "No matter how far it stretches, it pulls back to where it belongs." Say: "God's love is like that. When His people ran far away, His love pulled them back. Today we meet a prophet whose own family showed God's never-quitting love." Then hold up the plumb line: "Builders use this to see if a wall is straight. God used it to show a prophet named Amos something too!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Once there was a prophet named Hosea. God told him to do something very hard. "Hosea, marry a woman named Gomer, and keep loving her, even though she won't always love you back."
>
> Hosea obeyed. He married Gomer, and they had three children. But Gomer stopped loving Hosea. She ran away and chased after other things she thought would make her happy. That broke Hosea's heart.
>
> Then God said something surprising: "Go, show your love to your wife again." Hosea found Gomer. She was in a lot of trouble and had become like a slave. So Hosea paid fifteen pieces of silver and some barley to buy her back! He brought her home and said, "You are mine, and I am yours."
>
> Why did God ask Hosea to do this? Because it was a picture of God's own love! God's people kept running away from Him and loving fake gods. But God said, "When Israel was a child, I loved him... I led them with cords of human kindness, with ties of love." God would not give up on them.
>
> God sent other messengers too. A prophet named **Joel** saw a giant swarm of locusts, grasshopper-like bugs, eat every plant in the land. Joel said, "Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and compassionate!" And God made a wonderful promise through Joel: "I will pour out my Spirit on all people."
>
> Next, God chose a shepherd and farmer named **Amos**. Amos was not a fancy preacher. He took care of sheep and fig trees! But God sent him to the rich people of Israel, who were being unfair to the poor. God showed Amos a plumb line, a string with a weight that hangs perfectly straight. God said, "I'm measuring my people. Are they straight or crooked?" Amos shouted, "Let justice roll on like a river!"
>
> Finally, the prophet **Obadiah** wrote the shortest book in the Old Testament, just one chapter! He warned the proud nation of Edom, "You cheered when Jerusalem was hurt. As you have done, it will be done to you."
>
> Hosea, Joel, Amos and Obadiah all said: Come back to God. Be fair. Be humble. And God's love will not quit. Years later, Jesus came to buy us back, not with silver, but with His own life on the cross. That's love that never quits!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Keep it to the main idea: *God loves me even when I run away.* Play "run and come back": kids "run" (walk) to the wall, then you call "Come back, I love you!" and they run back for a hug (high five).

- **Explorers:** Learn Group 1 with the sentence "Happy Jellyfish Ate Oranges" (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah). Make a real plumb line with string and a washer and check the classroom door.
- **Trailblazers:** Read Hosea 3 and 1 Peter 1:18–19 (redeemed "not with perishable things such as silver or gold… but with the precious blood of Christ"). Read Acts 2:16–21 and see Joel quoted at Pentecost.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Amos 5:21–24: God rejected worship that came with injustice. What would Amos say to churches today? Discuss Obadiah's warning about gloating over enemies (compare Proverbs 24:17).

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Did Hosea keep loving his wife? (Yes!) (2) Does God keep loving you? (Yes!) (3) What bugs did Joel see? (Locusts / grasshoppers!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did Hosea pay to bring Gomer home? (Fifteen silver pieces and barley.) (2) What was Amos's job before he was a prophet? (Shepherd and fig farmer.) (3) Which book is only one chapter long? (Obadiah.)
- *Trailblazers:* (1) How is Hosea's story like the gospel? (2) What does a plumb line show, and what was God "measuring"? (3) Where is Joel 2:28 quoted in the New Testament?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Why do you think God used a marriage to picture His covenant? (2) What injustices would Amos speak against today? (3) How do you respond when someone you don't like gets in trouble?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Hosea" (or "Minor Prophets")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Hosea
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Amos" / "Hosea"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Amos
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Hosea," "Overview: Joel," "Overview: Amos," "Overview: Obadiah" (each about 6–8 min; pick one or two)	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Hosea

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) What did the video show about God's love for His people? (2) What did God want His people to change?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Minor Prophet Line-Up Race*, see Games #1.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Never-Quitting Heart Chain* and *Plumb Line Craft*, see Activities #1. Coloring Page 1: "Hosea Brings Gomer Home."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Introduce Micah 6:8 (all ages) and "Walk humbly with your God" (Little Lambs). Spell **H-O-S-E-A**, **J-O-E-L**, **A-M-O-S**, **O-B-A-D-I-A-H**. Learn Group 1: "Happy Jellyfish Ate Oranges."

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You that Your love never quits, even when we run away. Help us to be fair and kind and humble. Thank You for Jesus, who brought us back to You. Amen.

Week 2: "Jonah Runs, God Rescues" (Jonah, Micah, Nahum)

Scripture: Jonah 1–4 (key verses 1:1–3, 17; 2:9–10; 3:10; 4:2, 11); Micah 5:2; 6:8; Nahum 1:7

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God gives second chances, that God loves all people (even enemies), that Micah said Jesus would be born in Bethlehem, and that God is a safe place in trouble (Nahum).

Opening hook / object lesson: "Which Way?"

- *Supplies:* Two signs: "NINEVEH →" and "← TARSHISH," a toy boat or paper boat, a spray bottle of water (for "storm" mist, optional), a blue sheet.
- *Do:* Put the signs on opposite walls. "God told someone to go THIS way (point to Nineveh). Which way do you think he went?" Have a volunteer walk toward Tarshish with the boat. "Uh oh. Let's find out what happens when we run from God!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> God spoke to a prophet named Jonah. "Go to the great city of Nineveh and preach against it, because the people there are doing very wicked things."
>
> But Jonah did NOT want to go to Nineveh. The people there were enemies of Israel, and they were mean and cruel. So Jonah ran away! He went down to the port city of Joppa and got on a ship going to Tarshish, the opposite direction, as far away as he could go!
>
> But you can't run away from God. God sent a great wind, and a huge storm crashed over the sea. *Whoosh! Crash!* The ship was about to break apart! The sailors were terrified. They threw their cargo overboard. They prayed to their gods. But Jonah was asleep down below!
>
> The captain woke him up. "How can you sleep? Get up and call on your God!"
>
> The sailors figured out that the storm was because of Jonah. Jonah said, "I worship the LORD, the God who made the sea and the dry land. I'm running from Him. Throw me into the sea, and it will become calm."
>
> The sailors didn't want to, but finally they did. *SPLASH!* And immediately the sea became calm.
>
> But God wasn't done with Jonah. God sent a huge fish to swallow him up! *GULP!* Jonah was inside the fish for three days and three nights. Inside that dark, smelly fish, Jonah prayed. "In my distress

> I called to the LORD, and he answered me... Salvation comes from the LORD!"
>
> Then God commanded the fish, and it spit Jonah out onto dry land. *BLEH!*
>
> God said again, "Go to Nineveh." This time Jonah went! He walked through the city shouting, "Forty more days and Nineveh will be overthrown!" And guess what? The people of Nineveh believed God! From the king all the way down to the poorest person, they said sorry to God and stopped doing evil. Even the king got off his throne and sat in the dust! So God had mercy and didn't destroy them.
>
> But Jonah was grumpy! "I knew you were gracious and compassionate, slow to anger and full of love," he complained. Jonah wanted his enemies punished. God gently taught Jonah: "Shouldn't I care about this great city with so many people?"
>
> God loves everyone, even people we don't like. Jesus said that Jonah's three days in the fish were a picture of His own three days in the tomb. Then Jesus came back to life, so that people from every city and nation could be saved!

Add-on (1 minute): "Two more prophets this week! **Micah** told us something amazing: the King would be born in little **Bethlehem**, and that's exactly where Jesus was born! And Micah gave us our memory verse: act justly, love mercy, walk humbly with your God. **Nahum** said that, years later, Nineveh went back to being cruel, so God finally stopped them. But Nahum also said, 'The LORD is good, a refuge in times of trouble.'"

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Act it out on a blue sheet "sea": rock the boat, splash, then everyone hides under the sheet (inside the fish) and counts "1, 2, 3 days!", then "BLEH!" and they pop out. Main idea: *God gives second chances.*
- **Explorers:** Use the "Which Way?" signs to retell the story with kids walking the route. Learn Group 2: "Jonah Met Nine Hungry fish" (Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk).
- **Trailblazers:** Read Matthew 12:38–41 and Matthew 2:1–6. Find Nineveh, Joppa and Tarshish (likely in Spain) on a map; notice how far opposite Jonah ran.
- **Ambassadors:** The book ends with a question (4:11) and no answer from Jonah. Why? Who is the "Nineveh" in your life, the person you'd rather God not bless? Discuss Nahum as the "sequel" to Jonah: God's patience has limits.

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What swallowed Jonah? (A big fish!) (2) Did God give Jonah another chance? (Yes!) (3) Where was Jesus born? (Bethlehem!)
- *Explorers:* (1) Why did Jonah run away? (2) What did Jonah do inside the fish? (He prayed.) (3) What did the people of Nineveh do when they heard God's message?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why was Jonah angry when God forgave Nineveh? (2) How is Jonah's "three days" like Jesus? (3) What are the three things Micah 6:8 says God requires?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Who were more obedient to God in Jonah 1, the pagan sailors or the prophet? What does that show? (2) How do Jonah and Nahum together show both God's mercy and His

justice? (3) Is there a group of people you struggle to want God to love?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Jonah" (or "Jonah and the Big Fish")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jonah
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Jonah"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Jonah
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Jonah," "Overview: Micah," "Overview: Nahum"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Jonah

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) What surprised you about how Jonah acted at the end? (2) What does this story teach us about God's heart for people?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Jonah Overboard!*, see Games #2.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Paper-Bag Big Fish*, see Activities #2. Coloring Page 2: "Jonah and the Big Fish."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **J-O-N-A-H**, **M-I-C-A-H**, **N-A-H-U-M**. Learn Group 2. Practice Micah 6:8 with motions: "act justly" (balance hands like scales), "love mercy" (hug), "walk humbly" (walk in place, head bowed).

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, You never stop giving second chances. Help us to obey You the first time, and help us love everyone, even people who are hard to love. Thank You for sending Jesus to Bethlehem. Amen.

Week 3: "Watch, Build & Trust" (Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah)

Scripture: Habakkuk 1:2; 2:1–4; 3:17–19; Zephaniah 3:17; Haggai 1:2–8, 12–14; Zechariah 4:6; 9:9

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that we can bring God our hard questions and still trust Him (Habakkuk), that God sings over His people (Zephaniah), that we should put God first (Haggai), and that the King would come riding on a donkey (Zechariah).

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Unfinished Tower"

- *Supplies:* A tower of blocks (or cups) only half-built, labeled "GOD'S HOUSE"; next to it, a fancy fully-built tower labeled "MY HOUSE"; a pair of binoculars (or toilet-paper-tube binoculars).
- *Do:* "Look at these two houses. One is finished and fancy. The other one, God's house, is only half done. Why do you think that is?" Let kids guess. "God's people had come home from Babylon, but they got so busy with their own houses that they stopped building God's house! God sent prophets to say, 'Put Me first!'" Hold up the binoculars: "And one prophet climbed a tower to watch for God's answer."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Before Babylon came, a prophet named **Habakkuk** looked around and saw lots of wrong things. People were fighting and being unfair. So Habakkuk prayed a brave, honest prayer: "How long, LORD, must I call for help, but you do not listen?"
>
> God answered, but it was a surprising answer. "I'm going to use the Babylonians to discipline my people."
>
> Habakkuk was confused. "But God, the Babylonians are even worse!" So Habakkuk said, "I will climb up my watchtower and wait to see what God will say."
>
> God answered: "Write it down. The answer will come, so wait for it." And God told Habakkuk, "The righteous person will live by his faithfulness." That means: people who belong to God keep trusting Him, even when they don't understand.
>
> And Habakkuk decided to trust. He sang, "Though the fig tree does not bud and there are no grapes on the vines... yet I will rejoice in the LORD, I will be joyful in God my Savior!" Even if everything goes wrong, God is still good.
>
> Around the same time, a prophet named **Zephaniah** warned about the "Day of the LORD." But he also shared one of the sweetest promises in the Bible: "The LORD your God is with you... He will take great delight in you... he will rejoice over you with singing." Imagine God singing a happy song about you!
>
> Many years later, after God's people came home from Babylon, they started rebuilding God's temple. But then they stopped. They got busy making their own houses nice and fancy with wooden walls, while God's house stayed a pile of rubble.
>
> So God sent a prophet named **Haggai**. Haggai said, "Is it a time for you to be living in your fancy houses while God's house is a ruin? Give careful thought to your ways!" The people listened! Zerubbabel the governor, Joshua the high priest, and all the people got to work. *Bang! Bang! Bang!*
>
> God also sent a prophet named **Zechariah** to cheer them on. Zechariah had amazing visions at night. In one, he saw a golden lampstand and two olive trees. God said, "Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit." The people didn't have to be strong; God's Spirit would help them finish! And they did. The temple was finished in 516 B.C.
>
> Zechariah also saw far into the future. He said, "Rejoice greatly! See, your king comes to you... lowly and riding on a donkey." About 500 years later, Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey while

> the people waved palm branches and shouted "Hosanna!" The King had come!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Build a block "temple" together while you say "Bang! Bang! Build God's house!" End with a donkey ride around the room (pretend reins). Main idea: *God loves me and sings over me.*
- **Explorers:** Learn Group 3: "Zebras Hop, Zebras March" (Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi). Have kids whisper prayers of "Why?" to God and then say "Yet I will rejoice!"
- **Trailblazers:** Compare Zechariah 9:9 with Matthew 21:1–11. Read Ezra 5:1–2 to see Haggai and Zechariah in the history books. Discuss Romans 1:17 and its use of Habakkuk 2:4.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Habakkuk as a model of honest doubt that ends in worship. Discuss Haggai's "paneled houses": what "houses" do we prioritize over God's kingdom (Matthew 6:33)?

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did the people stop building? (God's house!) (2) What does God do over you? (Sings!) (3) What animal did the King ride? (A donkey!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What question did Habakkuk ask God? (2) What did Haggai tell the people to do? (3) Which prophet said the King would ride a donkey?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Is it okay to ask God "why?" How did Habakkuk do it well? (2) What does "Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit" mean for us? (3) What do Haggai and Zechariah have in common?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) How does Habakkuk 3:17–18 apply when life falls apart? (2) What would it look like to "give careful thought to your ways" with your time and money? (3) Why did Jesus choose a donkey instead of a war horse?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Rebuilding the Temple" / "Palm Sunday"	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Rebuilding+the+Temple
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Haggai" / "Zechariah"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Zechariah
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Habakkuk," "Overview: Zephaniah," "Overview: Haggai," "Overview: Zechariah"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Habakkuk

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) Why did God want the people to finish the temple? (2) What did you learn about trusting God when things are hard?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Temple Builders Relay*, see Games #3.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Palm-Branch Donkey Parade*, see Activities #3. Coloring Page 3: "Build God's House!"

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **H-A-B-A-K-K-U-K** (double K!), **Z-E-P-H-A-N-I-A-H**, **H-A-G-G-A-I** (double G!), **Z-E-C-H-A-R-I-A-H**. Practice all 11 so far with Groups 1–3.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, even when we don't understand, we will trust You. Help us put You first. Thank You for singing over us with joy, and for sending Jesus our King. Amen.

Week 4: "The Messenger Is Coming" (Malachi + 🌉 The 400 Silent Years Bridge Lesson)

Scripture: Malachi 1:2; 3:1, 6; 4:2, 5–6; Galatians 4:4; Luke 1:5–17

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Malachi is the last book of the Old Testament, that Malachi promised a messenger would come to get people ready for the Lord, that God was "quiet" for about 400 years but was getting the world ready, and that the silence ended when God announced John the Baptist and Jesus. Kids will celebrate knowing all 39 Old Testament books!

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Long Wait"

- *Supplies:* A wrapped gift box labeled "PROMISE," an hourglass or timer, a roll of blue painter's tape, 4 big signs ("PERSIA," "GREECE," "ROME," "JESUS!"), a "Shhh!" sign.
- *Do:* Hold up the gift. "I have a present for you, but you have to wait for it." Set a 60-second timer and have everyone sit **completely silent**. (Ask: "Was that hard?") "Imagine waiting not one minute, but **four hundred years**! After Malachi, God's people waited and waited for God's promise. Today we'll cross the 'Silent Bridge' and see what God was doing while they waited." Before class, tape a long "bridge" line on the floor from one side of the room to the other, with the signs spaced along it.

📖 **Story script, Part 1: Malachi (read aloud):**

> The people of Jerusalem had come home and rebuilt the temple. But after a while, they got lazy about loving God. When they brought animals to sacrifice to God, they brought the sick ones, the blind ones, the ones that limped! They kept the best for themselves. And they stopped bringing their tithe, their gift of one-tenth to God.
>
> So God sent one last Old Testament messenger. His name was **Malachi**, which means "my messenger." Malachi began with these words from God: "I have loved you."
>
> Then Malachi said, "Would you give your governor a sick, limping animal as a present? Of course not! So why would you give one to God?" He said, "Bring the whole tithe... and see if I will not throw open the floodgates of heaven."

> Malachi reminded them, "I the LORD do not change." God was still faithful. And then Malachi gave a promise about the future: "I will send my messenger, who will prepare the way before me. Then suddenly the Lord you are seeking will come to his temple." And at the very end of his book, Malachi said, "I will send the prophet Elijah to you..." Someone like Elijah would come first, and then the Lord Himself would come!
>
> And that is the end of the Old Testament.

📖 **Story script, Part 2: 🌉 The 400 Silent Years (walk the bridge as you tell it):**

> *(Walk to the start of the tape line with the kids. Hold up the "Shhh!" sign.)*
>
> After Malachi, something strange happened. God didn't send any more prophets. No new Bible books were written. For about **four hundred years**, it was quiet. People called it the "silent years." But God was not asleep, and God was not gone. He was busy getting the world ready for the biggest event ever!
>
> *(Walk to "PERSIA.")* First, the Persian kings ruled. God's people were back home, waiting.
>
> *(Walk to "GREECE.")* Then a young king named **Alexander the Great** marched out of Greece and conquered almost the whole world! Soon, people everywhere were speaking the same language: **Greek**. And God's Word, the Old Testament, was translated into Greek, so people from many nations could read it! (Later, the New Testament would be written in Greek too!)
>
> Then a wicked king named Antiochus tried to stop God's people from worshiping God. He messed up God's temple with a fake god's altar. But a brave family called the **Maccabees**, led by Judas "the Hammer," fought back. They cleaned up the temple and gave it back to God. Jewish families still remember this every winter at **Hanukkah**, and Jesus Himself went to the temple during this festival (John 10:22)!
>
> *(Walk to "ROME.")* Then the mighty **Roman Empire** took over. The Romans built long, straight roads everywhere, and kept the peace so people could travel safely. A king named **Herod** made the temple huge and beautiful. Everywhere, God's people gathered in synagogues to read the Scriptures and pray. And they were waiting. "When will the Messiah come? When will God speak again?"
>
> *(Walk to the end of the line, "JESUS!" Pause. Whisper:)* And then one day, an old priest named **Zechariah** was working in the temple. Suddenly an angel appeared! It was **Gabriel**, the same angel who had visited Daniel hundreds of years before! Gabriel said, "Your wife Elizabeth will have a son, and you are to call him John... He will go on before the Lord, in the spirit and power of Elijah... to make ready a people prepared for the Lord."
>
> *(Shout:)* The silence was over! Malachi's messenger was coming: John the Baptist! And just a few months later, Gabriel visited a young woman named Mary and told her she would have a baby named **JESUS**!

> The Bible says, "When the set time had fully come, God sent his Son." God was never late. He was getting everything ready, right on time. And now we're ready to cross the bridge into the New Testament and **meet Jesus**!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Keep the bridge walk simple: "Shhh, quiet... quiet... quiet... JESUS IS COMING!" Let them jump at the end. Main idea: *God keeps His promises. Jesus came right on time.*
- **Explorers:** Let kids carry the signs and stand at each spot. Learn to say: "39 books in the Old Testament!" Celebrate finishing the Old Testament.
- **Trailblazers:** Read Daniel 2:36–45 and match the metals to empires (gold = Babylon, silver = Medo-Persia, bronze = Greece, iron = Rome) in the traditional evangelical reading. Then read Mark 1:1–4, which quotes Malachi 3:1 and Isaiah 40:3 together.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss "the fullness of time" (Galatians 4:4): language, roads, peace, the Septuagint, synagogues and longing. Ambassadors can lead the bridge walk for Little Lambs.

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who is the last Old Testament book? (Malachi!) (2) Was God asleep during the quiet years? (No! He was getting ready!) (3) Who came at the end of the bridge? (Jesus!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What does the name Malachi mean? ("My messenger.") (2) What language did lots of people speak because of Alexander the Great? (Greek.) (3) Who was the messenger who got people ready for Jesus? (John the Baptist.)
- *Trailblazers:* (1) What were the people doing wrong in Malachi's day? (2) Name three ways God got the world ready for Jesus during the 400 years. (3) Which angel broke the silence, and where else does he appear in the Bible?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Why might God have waited 400 years? (2) How does Malachi 3:1 connect the two Testaments? (3) What does it mean for your life that God is never late, even when He seems silent?

📺 Video for the week:

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Zechariah and Elizabeth" (the angel's visit; the start of the New Testament story)	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Zechariah+and+Elizabeth
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Between the Testaments" (if available) or "Malachi"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Between+the+Testaments
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Malachi"; theme video "Messiah"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Malachi

Preview every video before class. (If no "between the testaments" video is available on Bible Journey, use "Malachi" and teach the bridge with the timeline walk.) Follow-up questions: (1) What promise did Malachi leave the people waiting for? (2) How did God get the world ready for Jesus?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Cross the Silent Bridge*, see Games #4.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Bridge Timeline Walk / Bridge Craft*, see Activities #4. Coloring Page 4: "The Silent Bridge to Jesus."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **M-A-L-A-C-H-I**. Say all 12 Minor Prophets, then try ALL 39 Old Testament books! Begin oral check-offs. Optional bonus word for Trailblazers/Ambassadors: **intertestamental**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You that You always keep Your promises. Even when You seem quiet, You are working. Thank You for sending Jesus right on time. We can't wait to meet Him in the New Testament! Amen.

Week 5 (optional): "Old Testament Graduation Sunday"

Use the End-of-Phase Review & Celebration plan below. Run the *Old Testament Library Sort* (Games #5), finish oral check-offs, stamp Bible Passports, award the 🐋🌉 "Mighty Twelve" badge, and hold a mini "Old Testament Graduation" (paper graduation caps optional!).

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 "The Library Song," now with the Minor Prophets!

Sing Verses 1–4 to **"Ten Little Fingers"** (as in Phase 7), then switch to **"Yankee Doodle"** for the NEW Verse 5. Changing tunes helps kids feel that the Minor Prophets are a new "shelf" in the library. Every verse is written out below; it's cumulative!

Verse 1: LAW (5) *(tune: Ten Little Fingers)*

> Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, the books of the Law! Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, FIVE!

Verse 2: HISTORY (12)

> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and First and Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, then First and

> Second Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther: History! Twelve books of HIS-TO-RY!

Verse 3: POETRY / WISDOM (5)

> Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, they're Poetry and Wisdom! Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, that's FIVE!

Verse 4: MAJOR PROPHETS (5)

> I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel and Dan-iel, the Ma-jor Pro-phets! I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel, Dan-iel: FIVE!

Verse 5: MINOR PROPHETS (12), NEW! *(tune: Yankee Doodle)*

> *(Yankee Doodle went to town, a-riding on a pony…)* **Ho-se-a, Jo-el, A-mos, O-ba-di-ah, Jo-nah,** *(…stuck a feather in his cap and called it macaroni)* **Mi-cah, Na-hum, Ha-bak-kuk, Zeph-a-ni-ah, Hag-gai!**
>
> *(Chorus: Yankee Doodle, keep it up, Yankee Doodle dandy…)* **Zech-a-ri-ah, Mal-a-chi, the twelve Mi-nor Pro-phets!** *(…mind the music and the step, and with the girls be handy)* **Short books with a might-y word: the Old Tes-ta-ment's done!**

Tag (shout it!)

> Law and History, Poetry, Major, Minor, ONE-TWO-THREE! THIRTY-NINE! The Old Testament's DONE! *(Whisper:)* Shhh… 400 years… *(Shout:)* JESUS IS COMING!

(Teacher tip: The Yankee Doodle lines are a bit crowded. Practice Verse 5 slowly first, clapping each syllable, then speed up. Little Lambs can just shout "TWELVE!" and do the fish gulp.)

Hand motions for the 12 new books

Book	Motion
Hosea	Stretch arms out wide, then pull them back in to your chest: "Come home! Love that won't quit!"
Joel	Wiggle all ten fingers overhead like a locust swarm.
Amos	Hold a fist high and drop a pretend plumb line straight down.
Obadiah	Hold up ONE finger (one chapter!).
Jonah	Hands together like a fish mouth: open… GULP!

Book	Motion
Micah	Fingertips together to make a tiny roof (little Bethlehem).
Nahum	Stack fists high like a tower, then let them tumble down.
Habakkuk	Hand over eyes like looking out from a watchtower.
Zephaniah	Hands start at your heart and float outward like a song.
Haggai	Pound fist on palm twice like a hammer, then make a roof over your head with both hands (God's house).
Zechariah	Hold pretend reins and bounce (donkey ride).
Malachi	Cup a hand by your mouth and point far ahead: "He's coming!"

Review motions for books learned earlier (1–27). These match the motions used in earlier phases and the Books of the Bible Memory System:

Section	Book → motion
Law	Genesis: palms together like a book, open, sweep arms up (sunrise) · Exodus: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door" · Leviticus: fold hands in prayer, then raise them high · Numbers: count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand · Deuteronomy: two fingers up, tap your head, hand on heart
History	Joshua: march with a fist-trumpet · Judges: pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle · Ruth: scoop grain, then hug yourself · 1 & 2 Samuel: hold up 1 or 2 fingers, then cup your ear (listening) · 1 & 2 Kings: 1 or 2 fingers, then crown on head · 1 & 2 Chronicles: 1 or 2 fingers, then unroll a scroll · Ezra: stack fists like bricks · Nehemiah: hammer + shield · Esther: crown, then "speak up" hands at mouth
Poetry / Wisdom	Job: hands open up, then fold over heart · Psalms: strum a harp · Proverbs: tap your head with one finger · Ecclesiastes: blow a puff into your hand, then point up · Song of Songs: heart hands
Major Prophets	Isaiah: two fingers to lips, then hand up ("Send me!") · Jeremiah: shape clay in a circle · Lamentations: tears down cheeks, then arms up like a sunrise · Ezekiel: go floppy, then stand tall · Daniel: lion jaws snap shut

📣 Section Shout

> **Teacher:** "How many Minor Prophets?" **Kids:** "TWELVE MIGHTY MESSENGERS!" **Teacher:** "Are they small?" **Kids:** "SMALL BOOKS, BIG MESSAGE!" **Teacher:** "How many books in the Old Testament?" **Kids:** "THIRTY-NINE!" **Teacher:** "Who comes next?" **Kids:** "JESUS!"

Cumulative recall drill (5 minutes)

1. **Three Groups of Four:** Split the room into three teams. Team 1 shouts Hosea–Obadiah, Team 2 shouts Jonah–Habakkuk, Team 3 shouts Zephaniah–Malachi. Rotate.
2. **Silly Sentences:** "Happy Jellyfish Ate Oranges / Jonah Met Nine Hungry fish / Zebras Hop, Zebras March." Teacher says the sentence word, kids say the book.

3. **Section Stand-Up:** Teacher calls a section (Law, History, Poetry, Major, Minor); kids stand and say that section's books.
4. **Before & After (39 books):** "What's after Daniel?" (Hosea) "What's before Malachi?" (Zechariah) "What's after Obadiah?" (Jonah) "What's the last book of the Old Testament?" (Malachi)
5. **39-Book Countdown (Trailblazers+):** Say all 39 books while holding up fingers in groups of ten (four hands = 40, minus one!). Time it and beat your record.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on "Minor Prophets," "Jonah," "Malachi = last," and the motions. Celebrate "39!" as a big number.
- **Explorers:** Goal: say all 12 in order (using the three groups) and spell at least 8.
- **Trailblazers:** Goal: say all 39 Old Testament books in order without the song; one-word summary for each Minor Prophet.
- **Ambassadors:** Goal: say all 39; teach the three-groups trick to a younger class; explain the 400 Silent Years in 1 minute.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition & first sounds)

Book	First letter	Sound it out	Picture clue
Hosea	**H**	"h-h-h"	❤️ heart
Joel	**J**	"j-j-j"	🦗 bug
Amos	**A**	"ay"	📏 string
Jonah	**J**	"j-j-j"	🐋 fish
Micah	**M**	"m-m-m"	🏘️ little town
Haggai	**H**	"h-h-h"	🔨 hammer
Zechariah	**Z**	"z-z-z"	🫏 donkey
Malachi	**M**	"m-m-m"	📣 messenger

Game: "Two J's!" Which two Minor Prophets start with J? (Joel and Jonah!) Which start with Z? (Zephaniah and Zechariah!) Which start with H? (Hosea, Habakkuk, Haggai!) Which start with M? (Micah, Malachi!)

Explorers (book names)

1. Hosea
2. Joel
3. Amos

4. Obadiah
5. Jonah
6. Micah
7. Nahum
8. Habakkuk
9. Zephaniah
10. Haggai
11. Zechariah
12. Malachi

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocabulary words)

- Book names: all 12 above
- Vocab: **justice**, **mercy**, **humble**, **Nineveh**, **temple**

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocabulary with definitions)

Word	Definition
Repent	To turn around: change your mind and direction, away from sin and toward God (Jonah 3).
Redeem	To buy back or set free by paying a price (Hosea buying back Gomer; Jesus redeeming us).
Justice	Doing what is right and fair, especially for the poor and powerless (Amos 5:24).
Mercy / hesed	God's loyal, faithful, covenant love; kindness that keeps its promises (Micah 6:8; 7:18).
Day of the LORD	The coming time when God judges evil and rescues His people (Joel, Amos, Zephaniah, Malachi).
Tithe	A tenth of one's income or produce given to God (Malachi 3:10).
Intertestamental	"Between the Testaments": the roughly 400 years from Malachi to the New Testament.
Septuagint	The ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures (begun about 250 B.C. in Alexandria; abbreviated LXX).
Messiah	"Anointed One," the promised King; in Greek, *Christos* (Christ).

👏 Syllable-clap method

Book	Claps	Spell in rhythm
Ho-se-a	3	H-O · S-E · A
Jo-el	2	J-O · E-L
A-mos	2	A · M-O-S
O-ba-di-ah	4	O · B-A · D-I · A-H
Jo-nah	2	J-O · N-A-H
Mi-cah	2	M-I · C-A-H
Na-hum	2	N-A · H-U-M

Book	Claps	Spell in rhythm
Ha-bak-kuk	3	H-A · B-A-K · K-U-K
Zeph-a-ni-ah	4	Z-E-P-H · A · N-I · A-H
Hag-gai	2	H-A-G · G-A-I
Zech-a-ri-ah	4	Z-E-C-H · A · R-I · A-H
Mal-a-chi	3	M-A-L · A · C-H-I

Tricky-spot alerts: Habak**KK**uk (double K), Ha**GG**ai (double G), Ze**PH**aniah (PH = F), Ze**CH**ariah and Mala**CH**i (CH = K). Many of these end in "-IAH" (Obadiah, Zephaniah, Zechariah). "-IAH" (Hebrew "Yah") is a short form of God's name: Zechariah = "the LORD remembers," Obadiah = "servant of the LORD."

🏃 "Spell It Out" relay

1. Make teams of 4–6. Each team gets an envelope of letter cards for a book (Explorers: shorter books; Trailblazers/Ambassadors: Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Zechariah).
2. Letters are scattered across the room (face down). Runners take turns grabbing ONE letter at a time.
3. When the word is complete and in order, the whole team does that book's motion and shouts the book's "one word" (e.g., "HAGGAI: BUILD!").
4. *Bonus round:* The teacher calls "Next book!" and teams must spell the book that comes *after* the one they just spelled.
5. *Little Lambs:* Find the first letter only, then do the motion.

🐝 Mini spelling bee word list (with sentences)

Word	Use it in a sentence
Hosea	**Hosea** kept loving his wife.
Joel	**Joel** saw a swarm of locusts.
Amos	**Amos** was a shepherd who spoke for the poor.
Obadiah	**Obadiah** is the shortest book in the Old Testament.
Jonah	**Jonah** prayed inside the big fish.
Micah	**Micah** said the King would be born in Bethlehem.
Nahum	**Nahum** said the LORD is a refuge in trouble.
Habakkuk	**Habakkuk** waited on his watchtower.
Zephaniah	**Zephaniah** said God rejoices over us with singing.
Haggai	**Haggai** told the people to build God's house.
Zechariah	**Zechariah** said the King would ride a donkey.
Malachi	**Malachi** is the last book of the Old Testament.

Word	Use it in a sentence
Nineveh	Jonah finally preached in **Nineveh**.
humbly	Walk **humbly** with your God.
messenger	God promised to send a **messenger**.

📖 Read-aloud practice passage

> God sent **twelve** messengers with short books. **Hosea** showed God's love never quits. **Joel** saw locusts. **Amos** said, "Be fair!" **Obadiah** wrote just one chapter. **Jonah** ran away, but God sent a **big fish** to give him a second chance. **Micah** said Jesus would be born in **Bethlehem**. **Nahum** said God is good. **Habakkuk** trusted God when things were hard. **Zephaniah** said God sings over us. **Haggai** said, "Build God's house!" **Zechariah** said the King would ride a **donkey**. **Malachi** said a messenger was coming. Then God was quiet for **400 years**, getting the world ready for **Jesus**!

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. What swallowed Jonah?
2. True or False: The Minor Prophets are called "minor" because their books are short.
3. How many Minor Prophets are there?
4. Which city did God tell Jonah to go to?
5. Fill in the blank: "Walk humbly with your _____." (Micah 6:8)
6. What animal did Zechariah say the King would ride?
7. What is the last book of the Old Testament?
8. In which town did Micah say the King would be born?
9. True or False: Jonah obeyed God right away the first time.
10. How many days and nights was Jonah inside the fish?
11. What kind of bugs did Joel see eating all the crops?
12. How many books are in the Old Testament?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. Who said, "Salvation comes from the LORD"? (Who said it? Hint: from inside a fish)
14. Which book is the shortest in the Old Testament? (Which book?)
15. What was Amos's job before he became a prophet?
16. What did God show Amos to measure His people? (A plumb line / a sword / a scale)
17. Which prophet told the people to finish building the temple instead of their fancy houses?
18. Fill in the blank: "'Not by might nor by _____, but by my Spirit,' says the LORD Almighty." (Zechariah 4:6)
19. Which book says, "He will rejoice over you with singing"? (Which book?)
20. What does the name Malachi mean?

21. True or False: Nahum is about God judging Nineveh, the same city Jonah preached to.
22. Which prophet climbed a watchtower to wait for God's answer?
23. Fill in the blank: Jonah ran to a ship going to _____.
24. Which nation (descendants of Esau) did Obadiah warn?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

25. Who said, "I knew that you are a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in love," and was upset about it? (Who said it?)
26. Which Minor Prophet's verse did Peter quote on the day of Pentecost?
27. Which verse from Habakkuk is quoted in Romans, Galatians and Hebrews? (Fill in: "The righteous person will live by his _____.")
28. Which Minor Prophet predicted thirty pieces of silver?
29. Which Old Testament verse did the chief priests quote to tell Herod where the Messiah would be born?
30. What was the name of Hosea's wife?
31. Who was the governor encouraged by Haggai and Zechariah to rebuild the temple?
32. Who did Jesus say was the "Elijah" Malachi promised?
33. Which conqueror spread the Greek language during the silent years?
34. What festival comes from the Maccabees rededicating the temple, and where is it mentioned in the New Testament?
35. Which angel broke the 400 years of silence by appearing to Zechariah the priest?
36. Which empire controlled Judea when Jesus was born?
37. True or False: In the Hebrew Bible, the twelve Minor Prophets were copied together on one scroll.
38. Fill in the blank: "But when the set _____ had fully come, God sent his Son." (Galatians 4:4)

🔑 Answer Key

1. A huge fish (Jonah 1:17)
2. True
3. Twelve
4. Nineveh
5. God
6. A donkey (Zechariah 9:9)
7. Malachi
8. Bethlehem (Micah 5:2)
9. False, he ran away first.
10. Three days and three nights
11. Locusts
12. 39
13. Jonah (Jonah 2:9)
14. Obadiah (21 verses)
15. A shepherd and a farmer of sycamore-fig trees (Amos 1:1; 7:14)
16. A plumb line (Amos 7:7–8)
17. Haggai
18. power

19. Zephaniah (3:17)
20. "My messenger"
21. True
22. Habakkuk (2:1)
23. Tarshish
24. Edom
25. Jonah (Jonah 4:2)
26. Joel (Joel 2:28–32 in Acts 2:16–21)
27. faithfulness (Habakkuk 2:4)
28. Zechariah (11:12–13)
29. Micah 5:2 (Matthew 2:5–6)
30. Gomer
31. Zerubbabel (with Joshua the high priest)
32. John the Baptist (Matthew 11:13–14; 17:12–13)
33. Alexander the Great
34. Hanukkah, the Festival (Feast) of Dedication (John 10:22)
35. Gabriel (Luke 1:19)
36. The Roman Empire (Caesar Augustus; Herod was a local king under Rome)
37. True ("The Book of the Twelve")
38. time

Games

🎮 Game #1: Minor Prophet Line-Up Race

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors (Little Lambs with buddies)
- **Supplies:** Two sets of 12 cards, each with a Minor Prophet name (and picture symbol for younger kids)
- **Setup:** Two teams. Shuffle each set and give one card to each player (if a team has fewer than 12 players, some get two).
- **How to play:** On "GO!", each team must line up in correct Bible order, holding their cards at chest level, and then shout the books in order with motions.
- **How to win:** First team in correct order wins the round. Play best of 3, reshuffling each time.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Use only Group 1 (4 cards) or Group 2. *Older:* Add the 5 Major Prophets (17 cards) or do it silently (no talking!).
- **Learning goal:** Book order for all 12 Minor Prophets.

🎮 Game #2: Jonah Overboard!

- **Best for:** All ages (very active)
- **Supplies:** A big blue sheet or tarp (the sea), a hula hoop or taped square (the boat), a beach ball (the big fish)
- **Setup:** Lay the blue sheet on the floor around the "boat." Everyone starts in the boat.

- **How to play:** The teacher is the "Storm." Call out commands: "Wind blows: rock left!" "Waves crash: crouch down!" "Throw cargo: toss pretend boxes!" "Sailors pray: fold hands!" Then the teacher asks a trivia question to one player. A wrong answer means "Jonah overboard!": that player jumps into the "sea." Players in the sea can get back in the boat when the "big fish" (beach ball) is rolled to them and they answer a question correctly ("GULP... BLEH!").
- **How to win:** Players still in the boat at the end, or the whole class "gets to Nineveh" if everyone ends in the boat.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* No one stays out; just do the motions and splash. *Older:* Use harder trivia and "Before & After" book questions.
- **Learning goal:** Jonah's story; God's second chances; trivia review.

🎮 Game #3: Temple Builders Relay

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Cardboard boxes, cups or large blocks (about 12 per team), each labeled with a Minor Prophet (or all 39 OT books for older kids)
- **Setup:** Blocks are piled at the far end of the room. Teams line up at the start.
- **How to play:** One runner at a time runs to the pile, finds the next book in order, and brings it back. The team stacks them in order to build a "temple wall" (Hosea at the bottom, Malachi at the top). If a block is out of order, Haggai (the teacher) calls "Give careful thought to your ways!" and the team must fix it.
- **How to win:** First team to build a 12-block tower in correct order that stands for 5 seconds wins.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Blocks have pictures; just stack them, and the teacher helps with order. *Older:* Build all 39 OT books in order, sorted by section.
- **Learning goal:** Book order; Haggai's message to put God first.

🎮 Game #4: Cross the Silent Bridge

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Painter's tape "bridge" (two parallel lines about 2 feet apart across the room), signs: MALACHI (start), PERSIA, GREECE, ROME, JESUS! (finish)
- **Setup:** Kids line up at MALACHI. Teacher stands at JESUS!
- **How to play:** It's a silent game! Kids must cross the bridge without making a sound (no talking, no giggling!). At each sign, the teacher holds up a card with a question (shown, not said aloud, or acted out); kids answer by doing a motion or pointing (e.g., "Show me the Jonah motion!" "Hold up fingers: how many Minor Prophets?"). Anyone who makes a sound goes back one sign. At the end, everyone who reaches "JESUS!" can finally shout as loud as they want: "JESUS IS COMING!"
- **How to win:** Everyone who crosses wins. The class wins together when everyone reaches the end.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Allow whispers; teacher helps. *Older:* Questions are about the 400 years ("Show me with fingers about how many years," "Point to the empire that spread Greek").
- **Learning goal:** The 400 Silent Years; the waiting and the joy of Jesus' coming.

🎮 Game #5: Old Testament Library Sort

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors (review Sunday)
- **Supplies:** 39 cards (one per OT book) per team; 5 colored "shelf" mats or baskets labeled Law, History, Poetry/Wisdom, Major Prophets, Minor Prophets
- **Setup:** Shuffle the cards and place them in a pile in the center for each team.
- **How to play:** Teams race to sort all 39 books onto the correct shelves, *and in correct order* on each shelf.
- **How to win:** First team with all 39 correctly sorted and ordered. (Ambassadors can be the "librarians" who check.)
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Little Lambs sort only the Minor Prophets with picture cards, or match pictures to "Jonah" and "Malachi." *Older:* No section labels; they must name the sections themselves.
- **Learning goal:** Mastery of all 39 Old Testament books and their sections.

🎮 Game #6 (bonus): Locust Swarm Tag

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers
- **Supplies:** Green scarves or pinnies for "locusts"; paper "crops" (green paper leaves) scattered on the floor
- **How to play:** Locusts (2–3 kids) try to tag the "farmers." Farmers protect the crops by standing on them. When tagged, a farmer must "rend your heart" (put a hand on their heart) and say "Return to the LORD!", then they're free again. After 2 minutes, count how many crops are left.
- **Learning goal:** Joel's message to turn back to God; God restores "what the locusts have eaten" (Joel 2:25).

Coloring Pages

> 🖍️ Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-08-printables.html`.

Page 1: "Hosea Brings Gomer Home" (Week 1)

- **Scene:** A dusty road leading to a little house with a warm, glowing window. Hosea walks hand-in-hand with his wife, both smiling. Three children run out of the house to greet them. A big heart shape is drawn in the clouds above.
- **Caption:** "I led them with cords of human kindness, with ties of love." (Hosea 11:4)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "How do you think Hosea felt bringing his wife home?" "How does God feel when we come back to Him?" "Who can you show never-quitting love to?"

Page 2: "Jonah and the Big Fish" (Week 2)

- **Scene:** Underwater: a huge fish with its mouth open, and Jonah (on his knees, praying) visible inside a cut-away "window" in the fish's belly, with seaweed wrapped around his head (Jonah 2:5). Above the water, a small ship sails away under clearing storm clouds. In the corner, a tiny picture of the city of Nineveh on the shore.
- **Caption:** "Salvation comes from the LORD." (Jonah 2:9)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What did Jonah do inside the fish?" "Have you ever run away from doing the right thing?" "How did God give Jonah a second chance?"

Page 3: "Build God's House!" (Week 3)

- **Scene:** Workers on scaffolding stacking big stones for the temple; Zerubbabel holding a building plan; Haggai pointing up and cheering. A golden lampstand with two olive trees in a small "dream bubble" in the corner (Zechariah's vision). Fancy houses with wooden walls in the background, with a sign "My House" crossed out and "God's House First!" written above.
- **Caption:** "Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit." (Zechariah 4:6)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What does it mean to put God first?" "What would you build for God?" "How does God's Spirit help us?"

Page 4: "The Silent Bridge to Jesus" (Week 4)

- **Scene:** A long stone bridge stretching across the page. On the left bank: an old scroll labeled "MALACHI" and a messenger pointing across. Along the bridge: small pictures of a Persian crown, a Greek helmet (Alexander), a menorah/lampstand (Hanukkah), and a Roman road sign. On the right bank: a bright star over a stable in Bethlehem, and the angel Gabriel. The bridge's railing says "SHHH... 400 YEARS..." and the right end bursts with "JESUS!"
- **Caption:** "When the set time had fully come, God sent his Son." (Galatians 4:4)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "Have you ever had to wait a really long time for something?" "What was God doing during the quiet years?" "Who did God send at the right time?"

Page 5: "Your King Comes on a Donkey" (bonus)

- **Scene:** Jesus riding a young donkey through a city gate; children waving palm branches; coats laid on the road.
- **Caption:** "See, your king comes to you... riding on a donkey." (Zechariah 9:9)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "Zechariah said this 500 years early! How did he know?" "Why do you think the King came on a donkey instead of a big war horse?"

Page 6: "Twelve Mighty Messengers" book-name page

- **Scene:** Twelve fish swimming in a big ocean wave, each fish labeled with a Minor Prophet in order, with its small symbol (heart, locust, plumb line, "1," fish, little house, tower, watchtower, music note, hammer, donkey, megaphone). At the bottom, a bridge leading to a sign: "NEW TESTAMENT →."
- **Caption:** "Walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8)

- **Coloring conversation prompts:** Say each name as you color its fish. "Which prophet is your favorite? Why?"

Activities & Crafts

❤️ Activity #1: Never-Quitting Heart Chain & Plumb Line (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Red and pink paper strips (1" × 8"), glue sticks or tape, markers; string, metal washers, craft sticks.
- **Steps (Heart Chain):**
  1. On each strip write one way God shows love (or one way kids can show love to others).
  2. Loop and glue the strips into a paper chain. Talk about how a chain holds on, like God's love.
  3. Add a heart tag that says "God's love won't quit!" (Hosea).
- **Steps (Plumb Line):** Tie a washer to a 12" string, then tie the other end to a craft stick labeled "AMOS: Let justice roll!" Let kids test whether things in the room are straight.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-cut and pre-written strips; they glue. *Explorers:* Write their own. *Trailblazers:* Write a different Minor Prophet's name on each link (in order!). *Ambassadors:* Write "justice" action ideas (help a classmate, give to a food drive) on the plumb line tag.
- **What it teaches:** God's faithful love (Hosea) and His care for fairness (Amos).

🐋 Activity #2: Paper-Bag Big Fish (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Brown or white paper lunch bags, newspaper or tissue for stuffing, blue/gray paint or crayons, googly eyes, rubber bands, a small paper "Jonah" figure (print or draw).
- **Steps:**
  1. Color or paint the bag like a big fish (scales, fins).
  2. Stuff it lightly with newspaper, but first slip the paper Jonah inside!
  3. Twist the open end and wrap it with a rubber band to make a tail.
  4. Add googly eyes and a big smile.
  5. Write "Salvation comes from the LORD! (Jonah 2:9)" on the side.
  6. At home, kids can "BLEH!" Jonah out by opening the tail and retelling the story.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-stuffed bags; just decorate. *Explorers:* Full craft. *Trailblazers:* Write Jonah's 4 chapters on the 4 fins (Runs, Prays, Preaches, Pouts). *Ambassadors:* Lead the craft and retell the story to Little Lambs using the fish.
- **What it teaches:** Second chances and God's mercy for all.

🌿 Activity #3: Palm-Branch Donkey Parade (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Green construction paper, child-size handprint tracing, tape, paper towel tubes or craft sticks; for the "donkey": a gray paper plate, paper ears, yarn.
- **Steps:**
  1. Trace both hands on green paper and cut them out (teacher helps).
  2. Tape the hands to a paper towel tube in a fan shape to make a palm branch.
  3. Write "Zechariah 9:9" on the tube.

4. Make a donkey face mask from the gray paper plate (optional).
5. Parade around the room (or into the main service!) waving branches and shouting "Hosanna! The King is coming!"

- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-cut hands. *Explorers:* Write the 4 Week 3 book names on the fingers. *Trailblazers:* Add the Matthew 21:5 reference and compare it to Zechariah 9:9. *Ambassadors:* Organize and lead the parade; read Zechariah 9:9 aloud as it begins.
- **What it teaches:** Old Testament promises came true in Jesus, our humble King.

🌉 Activity #4: The Bridge Timeline Walk & Bridge Craft (Week 4 Bridge Lesson)

- **Supplies:** Long butcher paper or painter's tape on the floor; cardstock strips (for a bridge craft); markers; stickers or printed symbols (scroll, crown, Greek helmet, menorah, Roman road, star).
- **Steps (Timeline Walk):**
  1. Lay out the floor bridge with 6 "stops": Malachi (~430 B.C.) → Persia → Alexander & the Greek language (333 B.C.) → the Septuagint (~250 B.C.) → the Maccabees & Hanukkah (164 B.C.) → Rome takes over (63 B.C.) → Herod & the temple → Gabriel & Zechariah → JESUS!
  2. At each stop, a kid (or Ambassador) reads a one-sentence card explaining it.
  3. Everyone walks silently between stops and cheers at the end.
- **Steps (Bridge Craft):**
  1. Fold a cardstock strip into an arch and glue its ends to a base strip.
  2. Write "MALACHI" on the left end and "MATTHEW" on the right end.
  3. Along the arch write "400 Silent Years: God was getting ready!"
  4. Add symbol stickers along the arch in order.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Walk the bridge; decorate a pre-folded arch with a star sticker at the end. *Explorers:* Full craft with 4 symbols. *Trailblazers:* Add dates. *Ambassadors:* Prepare and read the stop cards; explain "the fullness of time."
- **What it teaches:** God was working during the quiet years and brought Jesus at exactly the right time. This links the Old and New Testaments.

✅ Activity #5: Micah 6:8 Challenge Cards

- **Supplies:** Index cards in three colors (one each for "Act Justly," "Love Mercy," "Walk Humbly"), markers, a small envelope per child.
- **Steps:**
  1. Brainstorm one action for each phrase (Act justly: "Take turns fairly." Love mercy: "Forgive my brother." Walk humbly: "Pray before school.").
  2. Write or draw one action on each colored card.
  3. Put them in an envelope labeled "Micah 6:8 Challenge."
  4. Next week, kids report which ones they did; give a sticker for each.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Draw pictures; teacher writes. *Explorers/Trailblazers:* Write their own. *Ambassadors:* Make a 7-day challenge chart and share it in a group chat or with family.
- **What it teaches:** Living out the memory verse in everyday life.

📚 Activity #6: The Old Testament Bookshelf

- **Supplies:** A 39-slot "bookshelf" poster (5 shelves, color-coded by section) and 39 "book spine" strips (1" wide) in matching colors, glue, markers.
- **Steps:**
  1. Kids write a book name on each spine (or get pre-printed spines).
  2. Glue the spines onto the correct shelf, in order.
  3. Decorate the top: "I know the WHOLE Old Testament! 39 of 66."
  4. Leave room for a new "New Testament" bookshelf next month.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Glue only the 12 Minor Prophet spines (pre-printed). *Explorers+:* All 39. *Ambassadors:* Add a one-word summary to each spine.
- **What it teaches:** The structure of the Old Testament library; celebrates completing it.

Word Puzzles

🔀 Word Scramble

Unscramble these words from Phase 8.

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	NOHAJ	Swallowed by a fish
2	ESOHA	Love that won't quit
3	SOMA	Shepherd prophet
4	LOJE	Saw locusts
5	CHAMI	Bethlehem prophet
6	IAHCLAM	Last book of the OT
7	AGIGAH	"Build God's house!"
8	KUKBAKAH	Watchtower prophet
9	HEVENIN	Big city that said sorry
10	YEKDON	The King rode one
11	MEHLEBETH	Little town where Jesus was born
12	GERSSEMEN	Malachi's name means "my ___"
13	TENLIS	The 400 ____ years

Answer key: 1. JONAH 2. HOSEA 3. AMOS 4. JOEL 5. MICAH 6. MALACHI 7. HAGGAI 8. HABAKKUK 9. NINEVEH 10. DONKEY 11. BETHLEHEM 12. MESSENGER 13. SILENT

✏️ Fill-in-the-Blank Story

Word bank: Malachi, fish, Bethlehem, Jesus, Hosea, donkey, Nineveh, 400, temple, Jonah, twelve, Greek

> God sent _____ Minor Prophets. _____ kept loving his wife, showing God's love. _____ ran away from God, but a big _____ swallowed him. Finally he preached in _____, and the people said sorry to God. Micah said the King would be born in _____. Haggai told the people to finish God's _____. Zechariah said the King would ride a _____. _____ was the last book of the Old Testament. Then God was quiet for about _____ years. During that time many people learned to speak _____. Then, right on time, God sent _____!

Answer key: twelve, Hosea, Jonah, fish, Nineveh, Bethlehem, temple, donkey, Malachi, 400, Greek, Jesus

🔗 Match the Book to Its Picture / Summary

Book		Picture / Summary
1. Hosea		A. 🦗 Locusts; "I will pour out my Spirit"
2. Joel		B. 🔨 Finish building the temple!
3. Amos		C. ❤️ A husband's love that never quits
4. Obadiah		D. 🦟 Night visions; the King on a donkey
5. Jonah		E. 📏 A plumb line; "Let justice roll!"
6. Micah		F. 👀 Asked God "Why?"; "Yet I will rejoice"
7. Nahum		G. ☝️ One chapter against proud Edom
8. Habakkuk		H. 📣 "I will send my messenger"; last OT book
9. Zephaniah		I. 🐋 Ran from God; big fish; Nineveh repents
10. Haggai		J. 🏰 Nineveh falls; "The LORD is good, a refuge"
11. Zechariah		K. 🏘️ Bethlehem; "act justly, love mercy, walk humbly"
12. Malachi		L. 🎶 God rejoices over you with singing

Answer key: 1–C, 2–A, 3–E, 4–G, 5–I, 6–K, 7–J, 8–F, 9–L, 10–B, 11–D, 12–H

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (4–6)

1. Does God still love you when you do something wrong? (Yes!)
2. What did Jonah do inside the fish? (He prayed!)

3. How can you be kind to someone this week?
4. What town was Jesus born in? (Bethlehem!)
5. Is it hard to wait? Who did God's people wait for? (Jesus!)

Explorers (7–10)

1. Jonah didn't want to go to Nineveh. Is there something God wants you to do that feels hard?
2. What is one way you can "act justly" (be fair) at school or home?
3. Haggai said "Put God first." What is one way you can put God first this week?
4. How can you trust God when something bad happens, like Habakkuk did?
5. What was God doing during the 400 quiet years?

Trailblazers (11–13)

1. Why do you think God cared so much about the people of Nineveh?
2. Amos and Micah talk a lot about the poor. What does that show about God's heart?
3. Which prophecy about Jesus from these books is your favorite? Why?
4. Have you ever felt like God was "silent"? What does the 400-year bridge teach about those times?
5. What's the difference between giving God your "leftovers" and your best (Malachi 1)?

Ambassadors (14–17)

1. Jonah knew God was merciful and resented it. Where might you resent God's mercy to others?
2. How do Jonah and Nahum together show that God is both merciful and just?
3. Habakkuk wrestled with God honestly. How do you handle doubts or hard questions?
4. Micah 6:8: which part (justice, mercy, humility) is hardest for you? Why?
5. How did the events of the 400 Silent Years make the spread of the gospel easier in Acts?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. "Isn't Jonah just a fish tale, a myth?" *Suggested answer:* Jonah son of Amittai is a historical prophet mentioned in 2 Kings 14:25. Nineveh was a real, very large city (its ruins are near modern Mosul, Iraq). Jesus spoke of Jonah's experience and Nineveh's repentance as real events, setting them beside His own resurrection and the coming judgment (Matthew 12:39–41). If God can raise Jesus from the dead, He can certainly preserve Jonah in a fish. The question really comes down to whether miracles are possible, and the resurrection is the test case.

2. "If God is loving, why does Nahum celebrate the destruction of a city?" *Suggested answer:* Assyria was infamous for brutal cruelty to conquered peoples. God had shown mercy to Nineveh through Jonah about a century earlier, and they returned to violence. For the many nations Assyria had terrorized, Nineveh's fall was a rescue. Nahum 1:3 holds both truths: "The LORD is slow to anger but great in power; the LORD will not leave the guilty unpunished." A God who never judged evil would not be good. At the cross, God's justice and mercy meet: Jesus takes the judgment so the guilty who repent can be forgiven.

3. "Why should we trust that the Old Testament ended with Malachi? What about the books from the 400 years?" *Suggested answer:* Jewish tradition itself recognized that prophecy had ceased after the prophets of the Persian period (for example, 1 Maccabees 9:27 speaks of a time when prophets had ceased to appear, and the historian Josephus wrote similarly). Jesus referred to the Scriptures as "the Law of Moses, the Prophets and the Psalms" (Luke 24:44), matching the Hebrew Bible's three-part arrangement, which contains the same content as the Protestant 39-book Old Testament. The Apocrypha can be valuable history, but it doesn't claim the prophetic authority of "Thus says the LORD." The next prophet, John the Baptist, was announced by an angel, exactly as Malachi promised.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

Review game plan (last Sunday): "Old Testament Graduation"

1. **Welcome (10 min):** Sing all five verses of the Library Song. Do the Section Shout and the whisper-to-shout Tag ("Shhh... 400 years... JESUS IS COMING!").
2. **39-Book Speed Challenge (5 min):** Classes try to beat their best time.
3. **Old Testament Library Sort (15 min):** Games #5.
4. **Cross the Silent Bridge (10 min):** Games #4, with everyone crossing to the "New Testament" side of the room.
5. **Oral check-offs (15 min):** Use the checklists below; Ambassadors help.
6. **Graduation & Passport ceremony (15 min):** Paper graduation caps (optional), passport stamps, badges, certificates. Close by having the whole group say together, "We know all 39 books of the Old Testament! Next stop: Jesus!"

✅ Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (4–6)

- ☐ Says the section name: "Minor Prophets"
- ☐ Says at least 3 Minor Prophets (e.g., Jonah, Micah, Malachi)
- ☐ Knows "Malachi is the last book of the Old Testament"
- ☐ Says the Little Lambs verse: "Walk humbly with your God."

Explorers (7–10)

- ☐ Says all 12 Minor Prophets in order
- ☐ Spells all 12 (oral or written; Habakkuk/Zephaniah/Zechariah may be done with a buddy)
- ☐ Says Micah 6:8 from memory
- ☐ Sings the Library Song (all 5 verses)

Trailblazers (11–13)

- ☐ Says all 39 Old Testament books in order (no song)
- ☐ Gives a one-word summary for each Minor Prophet
- ☐ Says Micah 6:8 from memory

- [ ] Explains three ways God prepared the world during the 400 Silent Years

Ambassadors (14–17)

- [ ] Says all 39 Old Testament books in order
- [ ] Says Micah 6:8 and explains each of its three parts
- [ ] Teaches one Minor Prophet (story + motion + spelling) to a younger child
- [ ] Gives a 1-minute explanation of the 400 Silent Years and how Malachi 3:1 links to Mark 1:2

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp the **Minor Prophets** page with a blue fish stamp, AND stamp a special **"Old Testament Complete!"** page with a gold star. Kids write or trace: "I know 39 of 66 books, the whole Old Testament!"

🏅 Badge: "Mighty Twelve"

An ocean-blue shield with a cartoon big fish curving around twelve small gold stars. Beneath the fish, a small stone bridge with the words "400 YEARS → JESUS." Banner: "MINOR PROPHETS · 12 BOOKS · OLD TESTAMENT COMPLETE." (Cardstock badge, sticker, or iron-on patch.)

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Old Testament Graduate & Mighty Twelve Certificate**
>
> This certifies that _____ has completed **Phase 8: Twelve Mighty Messengers** and has learned the twelve Minor Prophets: **Hosea · Joel · Amos · Obadiah · Jonah · Micah · Nahum · Habakkuk · Zephaniah · Haggai · Zechariah · Malachi** and has learned **all 39 books of the Old Testament!**
>
> "He has shown you, O mortal, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8)
>
> **Books learned: 39 of 66** Teacher: _____ Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page

> ✂️ *Copy or print this section and send it home.*

Dear Families,

This month your child learned the **Twelve Minor Prophets**: **Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah and Malachi**. They are "minor" because

their books are short, but their messages are mighty: God's love never quits, God cares about justice and kindness, God gives second chances (just ask Jonah!), and a King is coming. Malachi, the last book of the Old Testament, promised a messenger would come to prepare the way. We also learned about the **"400 Silent Years"** between the Testaments, when God was quietly preparing the world for Jesus. **Your child now knows all 39 books of the Old Testament!** Next month we meet Jesus in the Gospels.

📖 **Memory Verse:**

> "He has shown you, O mortal, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8, NIV)
>
> *Little Lambs:* "Walk humbly with your God."

🎵 **This month's song verse (tune: "Yankee Doodle"):**

> Ho-se-a, Jo-el, A-mos, O-ba-di-ah, Jo-nah, Mi-cah, Na-hum, Ha-bak-kuk, Zeph-a-ni-ah, Hag-gai! Zech-a-ri-ah, Mal-a-chi, the twelve Mi-nor Pro-phets! Short books with a might-y word: the Old Tes-ta-ment's done!

(Ask your child to teach you the three silly sentences: "Happy Jellyfish Ate Oranges / Jonah Met Nine Hungry fish / Zebras Hop, Zebras March.")

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions:**

1. Why did Jonah run away from God? What did God do?
2. Micah 6:8 says to act justly, love mercy and walk humbly. Which one can our family practice this week?
3. God was quiet for 400 years but was getting the world ready for Jesus. Have you ever had to wait for something good?

👨‍👩‍👧 **Family activity: "Micah 6:8 Week"** Make three columns on the fridge: **Act Justly**, **Love Mercy**, **Walk Humbly**. Every time someone in the family does one (sharing fairly, forgiving, praying, serving), add a sticker or tally mark. At the end of the week, celebrate with a "Jonah" treat: Swedish Fish or goldfish crackers!

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search on YouTube; parents, please preview):

- **Sharefaith Kids:** "Jonah," "Hosea," "Zechariah and Elizabeth": https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jonah
- **Bible Journey:** "Jonah," "Amos," "Zechariah": https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Jonah
- **BibleProject (older kids & parents):** "Overview: Jonah," "Overview: Micah," "Overview: Habakkuk," "Overview: Malachi," and the theme video "Messiah": https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Jonah

Next month: *Meet Jesus!* Matthew, Mark, Luke and John, the four Gospels!